

Erling Haaland

In a season where he hasn't been at his best, Erling Haaland has still scored 26 league goals for title-chasing Manchester City.

There have been phases in the Premier League where Haaland has been curtailed by central defensive pairings, but can anyone bet against the free-scoring Norwegian producing the goods at the World Cup?

Norway has had to endure a painstaking wait to play at the FIFA World Cup. The country's last appearance came in 1998, 28 years ago, when it was eliminated in the round of 16 by Italy. Ironically, it was at the Azzurri's expense that the Scandinavian side eventually made it to the finals, topping Group I with a 100 per cent record. The leading man, Haaland, scored 16 goals in eight games to propel the team towards history.

Norway walks into the quadrennial tournament as an unknown quantity. There is no clear way to measure their ability to make it count on the grandest stage of all. But with a golden generation of players, it will be no surprise if they go deep into the tournament. For that to happen, Haaland will have to be at his best, staking a claim for the Golden Boot.

A positive World Cup campaign will not only enhance Haaland's stature as one of Europe's best centre-forwards, but also write his name into the annals of World Cup history as one of those flagbearers who lifted a less-fancied side to unprecedented heights.



NORWAY

Age - 25

Club - Manchester City

NT Appearances - 49

Goals - 55

Assists - 6